

The ultimate

Did you know that you can pack a dream PC into a form-factor that would make your game console jealous?

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Given the state of hardware and games today, you don't need a ridiculously expensive PC to have fun. A mid-range system is more than sufficient for most games and full-HD movies are a laugh on such a system. Keeping that in mind, the relatively modest hardware that you would require need not be stuffed into a capacious cabinet, all you need is an HTPC box and you can pack it to the brim with all the hardware that you'll ever need to build an enjoyable HTPC or "small-form-factor-PC."

The details of the configuration we settled on are given in the box overleaf, but you can easily mix-and-match to build your own rig. Basically, an i5 processor, a decent mid-range graphics card (such as a 560Ti or 650Ti) and about a TB or two of hard disk space are all you need for a worthwhile system in a reasonable budget. Of course, consoles like the Xbox One and PS4 would like to convince you that they're already doing that, but as any PC user knows, the extra effort and money spent on the system will more than justify itself in terms of the sheer power and flexibility (and even cost in the long run) that the build would offer you.

Regardless of what hardware you settle on for the PC, there are some basic items that you would require for any system. These are not compulsory of course, but they will go a long way in making your HTPC more accessible. The items are as follows:

- HD Webcam (chatting, obviously)

HTPC



Windows Media Centre

- Xbox 360 controller (wired or wireless depending on your budget)
- Wireless keyboard and mouse (what's a PC without these?)
- HTPC remote (movies and music will not be the same without it)
- Bluetooth headset (when disturbing your family is a bit higher up in your list of priorities)
- USB DAC (for the "audiophile")
- High-speed internet connection (4mbps or above, convince your parents that you can't have HD video without it)
- At least a 300N capable wireless router (for all your connectivity needs. USB support is a bonus)
- Android / iDevice (The right software can make these seem indispensable)
- A steam account and a library of steam games. (It's the best gaming service and is cross-platform and has a

massive game library and supports controller-based navigation via its "big-picture" mode)

Setting up a PC is a task that just about all you readers are familiar with, so we won't go through the entire setup process unnecessarily, suffice to say, be careful, don't force anything in the wrong way and make sure everything is plugged in properly before firing up your system for the first time. We've added images so you can use them for quick reference if you have any doubts.

Let's run through the tasks that we would expect our ideal HTPC to do:

- Multimedia playback: This is something we all expect, a seamless, integrated system that will playback your entire media collection without a hitch. We want a system that will give you an indexed library for you to browse through. Searching for and